On 4 March 1988, on his release from Ferozepur jail, Jasbir Singh Rode (nephew of Bhindranwale) started his march towards Golden Temple. Chaman Lal wanted to prevent him from entering the temple as he felt it would help in further fanning extremism in Punjab and it would subsequently be difficult to dislodge him and his militant followers from the temple. But he was overruled by Gill. As apprehended by Chaman Lal, after his appointment as Jathedar of Akal Takht, Rode made a fiery speech declaring he would fight for Khalistan, complete freedom and implementation of Anandpur Sahib resolution.

To register his protest, Lal held a press conference in Kotwali Amritsar and blamed K.P.S. Gill for following a wrong policy. Soon after that, Chaman Lal who had already become a 'liability' for K.P.S. Gill and his men, was asked to report to the home ministry at New Delhi in October 1988 and was finally repatriated to his cadre – Madhya Pradesh – after four months.

After a three year tenure as DGP Nagaland, Chaman Lal joined BSF Headquarters New Delhi as Additional DGP and finally retired in September 1996.

My experiences

Soon after Indira Gandhi's assassination, an unwritten decision was taken not to post any Sikh officer or staff member to the R&AW stations in west Europe and North America on the grounds that they could not be trusted. That decision also impacted the future intake of Sikhs into the Department. It was obvious that these decisions were taken at the highest level. Similar instructions might have been issued to other sensitive ministries and departments too. Even though I was privy to some of the most sensitive information the Department handled, I suddenly became ineligible for a posting to west Europe or North America, simply because I happened to be a Sikh and thus could not be fully trusted to be posted in these places. It was not the place of posting, but the procedure of selection that bothered me. That a segment of the Department's officers and staff members were not eligible for postings to certain regions because of